

What else to watch: *Nosferatu* (1922, p.330) ■ *The Last Laugh* (1924) ■ *Secrets of a Soul* (1926) ■ *Metropolis* (1927, pp.32–33) ■ *Dracula* (1931) ■ *Spellbound* (1945) ■ *The Third Man* (1949, pp.100–03) ■ *The White Ribbon* (2009, p.323)

Caligari, Cesare's "master," claims that his charge "knows all secrets" and invites the audience to ask a question. A visibly shaken Alan asks, "How long shall I live?"—to which Cesare replies, "Until dawn." And here we see another example of a horror-movie device lifted from countless tales: the fool who tempts fate. The unfortunate Alan is found dead the following morning.

Expressionist style

The look and style of the movie were heavily influenced by the legendary Max Reinhardt, director of the Deutsches Theatre in Berlin. His antirealist style, itself inspired by the Expressionist art movement of the early 20th century, embraced the artificiality of the theater set and manipulated darkness rather than light to create swathes of chiaroscuro, establishing an atmosphere of mystery and unease.

Wiene carefully employs lighting to suggest that this is simply an outlandish melodrama—a notion reinforced by the frequent use of

sinister close-ups, mostly of the seemingly insane Caligari, to persuade his audience that they are watching a straightforward hero-and-villain story. Yet when it is revealed that no character's perspective may be taken at face value, suddenly the strange, distorted angles and backdrops of the production design begin to make sense. They are an integral part of the story and not simply an unsettling style; the sets by Walter Reimann, Walter Röhrig, and Hermann Warm seem to portray a whole world gone mad.

One reason that *The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari* has endured is that, anticipating Hitchcock's *Psycho*, it is the first movie to take audiences inside the mind of a madman. Its

resonant horror stems from our fear of the mask of sanity that even the most disturbed individuals can wear in order to deceive those around them. ■

Robert Wiene Director

Robert Wiene was born in 1873 in Breslau. In 1913, he wrote and directed a short movie, *The Weapons of Youth*, which was the first of 20 features and shorts he would make in the silent era. After a prolific movie career in Germany, Wiene fled the Nazi regime in the early 1930s and moved to France. He died of cancer during the shooting of his last movie, *Ultimatum* (1938), which was completed, uncredited, by fellow émigré Robert Siodmak.

Key movies

1913 *The Weapons of Youth*
1920 *The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari*
1923 *Raskolnikow*
1924 *The Hands of Orlac*

Cesare carries away Francis's sweetheart, Jane, through a landscape resembling the aftermath of World War I, which had ended just two years earlier.

